‘A’ grade on both and was even recommended for a Himalayan expedition. Subsequently, I went to the HMI as an instructor for an adventure course for school children, including a few boys from Australia. I loved the mountains and discovered that I had a natural flair for climbing. Moreover, I could stand high altitudes better than most.

In 1968, our regiment, the Maratha LI, celebrated its bicentenary and was presented the colours by President Zakir Hussain. Each battalion had to select an officer to receive the colours from the president at a presentation ceremony. I consider myself extremely fortunate to have been nominated to receive the colours for 9 Maratha LI by our commanding officer, Lieutenant Colonel Awasthi. At a glittering ceremonial parade in our Regimental Centre at Belgaum, the colours were first consecrated by religious teachers and priests, and then they were presented to each battalion in turn by the president as the commander-in-chief of the armed forces. Our older battalions, whose origin dated back from 1768 to 1800, laid to rest their old colours presented by the British monarchs during this parade. In his address, the president said, ‘Your regiment has, during the last 200 years of existence, added many brilliant chapters to the glorious annals of the Indian Army.’

My parents, along with my elder brother, Flying Officer Satti Marwah, and sister Veena had come to witness this historical event. Later, when I took over the command of the same battalion in 1981, it was a rare personal achievement. Not every officer who received the colours that day was destined to command the same battalion.

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[1] Colonel R.D. Palsokar, *Forever in Operations, A History of 8 Mountain Division*, Vol. I, pp. 63–73.

[2] Ibid., p. 66.

[3] ibid., p. 68.